been amended over 100 times, then any policy can also be modified. Every scheme requires a modification based on the feedback on the ground," says former army chief General Manoj Mukund Naravane, who wrote in his memoirs *Four Stars of Destiny* (excerpts of which were released late last year) that Agnipath had taken the army "by surprise" and was a "bolt out of the blue" for the navy and the IAF. He wrote that the army's initial view was that 75 per cent of Agniveers could be retained and 25 per cent released.

Two batches of 40,000 Agniveers are currently serving in the Indian Army. Three batches of 7,385 Agniveers have completed training in the Indian Navy, and 4,955 Agniveer Vayu trainees are in the IAF. The overall intake has been capped at 175,000 till 2026. Intake of recruits will increase from 46,000 annually in the first four years to 90,000 in the fifth year and to 125,000 from the sixth year onwards.

Removing Differences

The Agnipath scheme's current structure provides substantial one-time compensation for death/ disability, but lacks the extensive benefits available to regular soldiers, prompting calls for revisions to address these gaps. Akshay Laxman Gawate was the first Agniveer to die in the line of duty since the introduction of the scheme. The 22-year-old died from medical complications in high-altitude conditions while serving at the Siachen Glacier in October 2023. Laxman's family received Rs 1 crore as a lumpsum compensation, including Rs 48 lakh non-contributory insurance, ex gratia relief of Rs 44 lakh and Rs 8 lakh from the Armed Forces Battle Casualty Fund.

In the case of a regular soldier who becomes a casualty, the defence ministry would have paid Rs 50 lakh as insurance, ex gratia payout between Rs 35-45 lakh and a gratuity. In addition, his widow or parents would be entitled to a lifelong family pension and health and canteen facilities. His children, too, would be allowed free education till graduation. If a child of a fallen solider clears a medical or an engineering entrance exam, the MoD pays their fee. Moreover, if a full-time soldier is disabled during operations, he gets treatment for life, a pension and an additional tax-free disability pension. An Agniveer gets a one-time payout depending upon his disability, varying from Rs 44 lakh for 100 per cent disability to Rs 15 lakh for 50 per cent or lesser disability as well as full pay for the remainder of his four-year period. He

A WORLD OF DISPARITIES

The terms of service for Agniveers are markedly different from those for regular soldiers

AGNIVEERS		REGULAR SOLDIERS
4 Years	YEARS OF SERVICE	**18** Years
30 Days Annually	LEAVE	**90** Days Annually
No pension; one-time payment of Rs 11.71 lakh (Seva Nidhi Fund)	PENSION	Lifelong pension
Promised priority in central/ state government jobs	PLACEMENT AFTER SERVICE	Army Welfare Placement Organisation helps find jobs for veterans, their widows/ wards
One-time payout of Rs 44 lakh for 100 per cent disability; Rs 15 lakh for lesser disability; Seva Nidhi Fund; no long-term medical care	DISABILITY BENEFIT	In addition to regular pension, entitled to an additional disability pension for life; lifelong access to medical facilities
One-time compensation of Rs 1 crore; salary for unserved period up to four years; Seva Nidhi Fund	DEATH DURING SERVICE	Rs 50 lakh insurance, Rs 35-45 lakh ex gratia payout, gratuity and battle casualty fund; next of kin entitled to family pension; support for children's education

REDIRECTING THE FIRE

Some of the changes in Agnipath recommended by the armed forces and other experts

- Bringing parity in service casualty/ disability dues between Agniveers and regular soldiers
- Setting up an agency like the Army Welfare Placement Organisation to help Agniveers find jobs after their exit
- Extending Agniveers' tenure of service to 7-8 years
- Increasing intake of Agniveers from 25 per cent to 50 per cent and above